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Before we move on to the details of the fighting in both NEFA and Ladakh, it is important to understand the historical canvas which was the backdrop to the clashes. In 1947, China was not on India's radar for the simple reason that it didn't share a common border with the subcontinent. To understand the claims and counter-claims, it is important to not only look at events as they unfolded north of the Great Himalayas—involving Tibet, Sinkiang, China, the Soviet Union and Mongolia—but also on the southern side of the mountain chain that involved not just the Indians but a host of others—the British, Sikhs, Dogras, Ladakh, Kashmir, Nepal, Sikkim, Bhutan, the various tribes inhabiting NEFA, Assam, Burma and finally, even the United States.

The border with China even today is an unresolved problem. Unlike the settlement and demarcation of frontiers between Nepal, Bhutan and Burma which also followed the Himalayan watershed principle, Mao Tse-tung did not want the boundary settled with India for the simple reason that with the passage of time, Chinese claims based on—what it wouldn't be inaccurate to call—the whims of its leader then would develop a legitimacy of their own. It is, therefore, even more vital for India's future generations to truly understand the genesis and complexities of our conflict with China—across the mountain border as well as on our side. The country would do well to heed the age-old saying that nations which do not learn from history are doomed to make the same mistakes again.